

for the device drivers can be built using either approach. A third approach is to use the binary device driver provided by the vendor as per the policy requirements.”

Licences needed

The open source licences mandated by the policy are:

1. Apache License, Version 2.0
2. Eclipse Public License, v 1.0
3. European Union Public License (EUPL v.1.1)
4. GNU General Public License, version 2 (GPLv2)
5. GNU General Public License, version 3 (GPLv3)
6. Mozilla Public License 1.1 (MPL 1.1)
7. The BSD License
8. The GNU Lesser General Public License, version 2.1 (LGPLv2.1)
9. The GNU Lesser General Public License, version 3.0 (LGPLv3)
10. The MIT License
11. Any other licence which gives users the freedom to copy, modify and redistribute driver source code without any restrictions.

The draft policy clarifies the necessity for so many open source licences. It states: “The widely used OSS licences are listed along with the generic Open Source Software License, which gives users the freedom to copy, modify and redistribute driver source code without any restrictions. Hence, the driver is made available by building the executable from the source code available under any one of the listed licences.”

Industry gives this move a thumbs up!

Adopting open source in e-governance is a major decision for the government. The move has been welcomed by the FOSS community, which gave a thumbs-up to the Department of Information Technology. Apart from the expert comments we received while compiling this story, we asked members of the *LINUX For You* community on Facebook to tell us what they felt about this move.

Ashraf Khan Mohamed, a Linux enthusiast and a member of the LFY community, says, “If this does not get derailed by the likes of Microsoft, I would like to believe that the GOI is finally getting around to accepting the fact that we in India need computing that is on our terms, and not at the mercy of some overseas behemoth bent upon profit and ‘world domination’. The next area that the GOI can formulate a policy for is regarding software applications for proprietary vendors (for example AutoCAD, Adobe PhotoShop, Tally etc) —they should also all be GPOS compliant.”

Yogesh GiriKumar, applications specialist with CSS Corp, Chennai, says, “This decision is going to result in major saving of government revenues. The government has had to spend crores of rupees year after year on proprietary software. This money can be saved and utilised for better purposes, if they switch over to open source.”

Probable issues

One cannot underestimate the tight grip of proprietary software on the Indian system. Be it our homes or colleges, offices or Internet cafes, we are fed with proprietary software at all times. It wouldn't be an exaggeration to call this a software addiction. In such a case, won't it be difficult to implement open source at the ground level? Yogesh answers this, “Training of human resources is the only aspect that needs to be worked upon. But open source systems have evolved to be very user-friendly over time, so I don't see much difficulty in learning these systems.”

However, Dharam Rohila, director, Netsoft Consulting Services, adds that changing the mindset of government employees is difficult. He says, “I have worked in the government as well as in the private sector. On the basis of my experience, I can say that it will take some time for employees to adopt this system.”

Adding to this, he said, “A separate implementation and monitoring body is required for the success of this venture. This will help solve implementation issues to a great extent.”

Yet another issue pointed out by Rohila is the integration of software. He says, “Integration can be a nightmare if different modules are bought from different vendors. For example, if the finance module is bought from a different vendor than that of the sales module, integrating the two can be a big problem. It will be better if different modules are purchased from the same vendor, to avoid any such integration issues.”

Experts opine that the government should resort to long-term solutions for adopting open source in e-governance. Pradeep Valsangkar, managing director and chief consultant, GCS Consulting Services Private Limited, says, “The Internet is flooded with ‘pre-cooked’ open source software. The government needs to guard against such solutions.”

The industry also emphasises the reliability of open source systems as compared to proprietary software. Girikumar says, “Reliability of software is one of the primary requirements for the state. However, terms such as ‘rock-solid’ and ‘fail-safe’ cannot be used to describe proprietary software. Till now, the reliability of most software has been atrocious. However, the foundation of Free and Open Source Software (FOSS) is high reliability. All the running gear of the Internet—TCP/IP, DNS, Sendmail, Perl and Apache are free software, which have demonstrated a level of reliability and robustness under rapidly changing conditions (including a huge and rapid increase in the Internet's size) that, when evaluated against the performance record of even the best of closed commercial software, is nothing short of astonishing.”

It goes without saying that the implementation of open source in e-governance is a welcome decision. How long it'll take to become a reality, only time can tell! 

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